Emergence of Bangladesh

From Ancient Periods to Arrival of Islam (up to 1204) : Locating Bengal

EMB 101 | Class 2

What is ‘Bengal’?

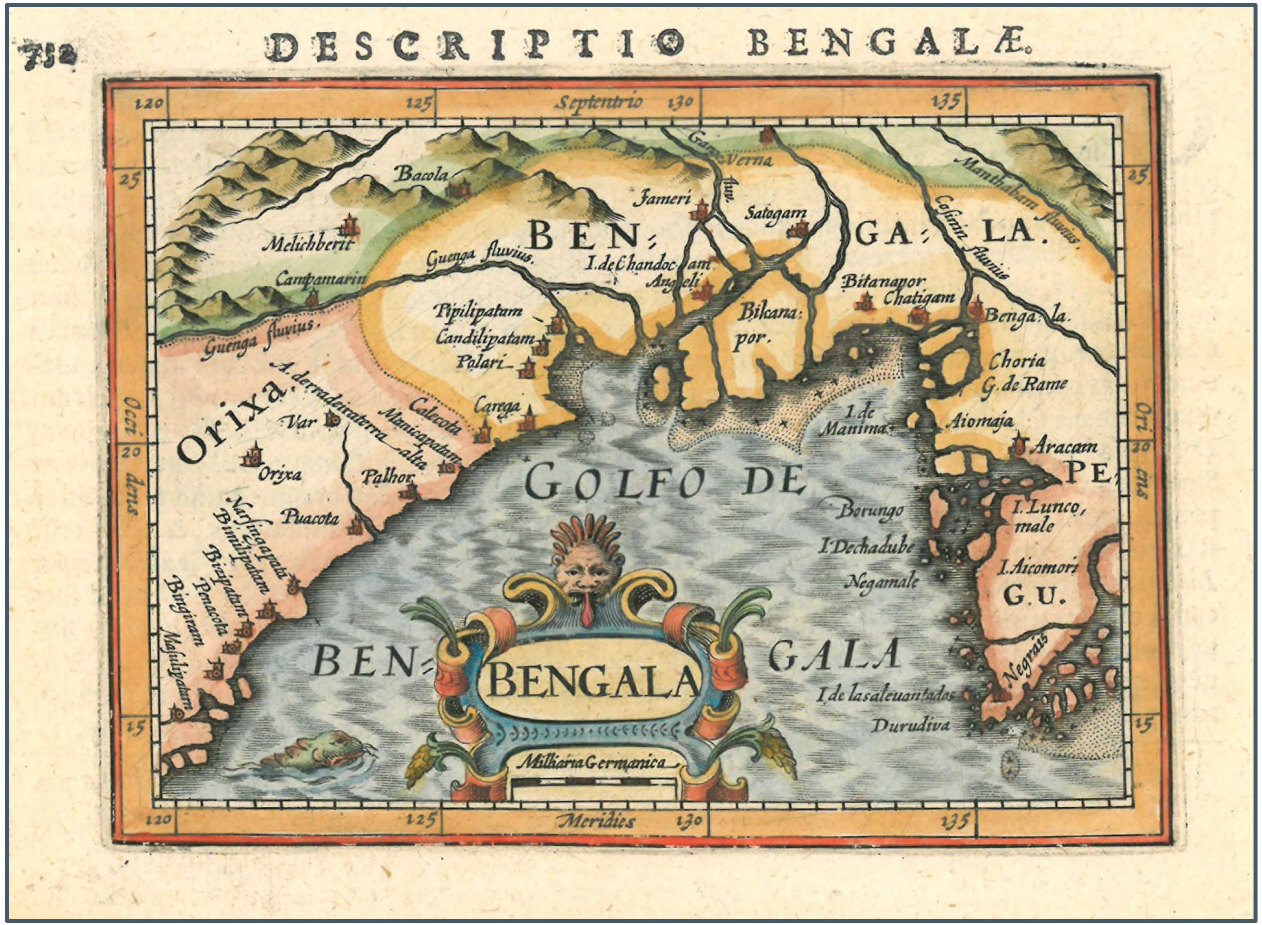
Rather than being a geographically defined region, Bengal represented a conceptual space oriented towards the lands surrounding the rivers, particularly the Ganges, that flowed towards the Bay of Bengal





German cartographer Sebastian Munster drew this first printed map of Asian continent.

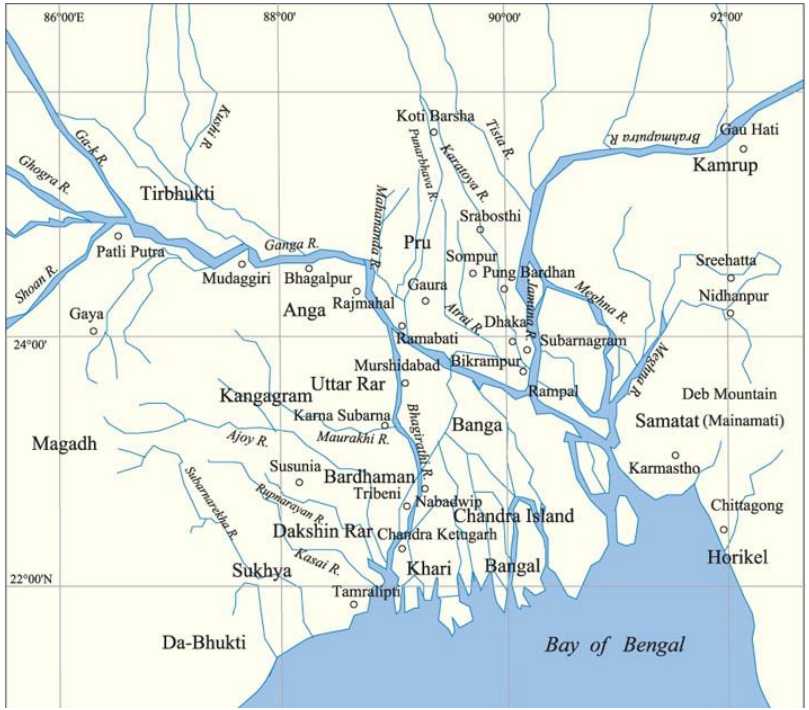
Bengal can be found near the river Ganges



First printed European map with Bengal as its title.

It is taken from the miniature atlas “Tabularum Geographicarum Contractarum” by the Flemish cartographer Petrus Betrius.

Ancient Bengal



Bengal has been a place for continuous human settlement because of its Geography and Climate. The rivers are the backbone of Bengal Delta that help to yield high crop productivity and promoted human settlement.

A place which ensures food-security always attracts people. By 2000 BCE, people started to settle around rivers and canals of this delta and practiced agriculture. It was around 1000 BCE, the growth of urban settlements i.e. the *Mahajanapadas* are found.

Wari- Bateshwar

Situated in Narsingdi, dating back to approximately 2450 years, this was the settlement of one of the ancient Mahajanapadas, an important trading centre and a river port

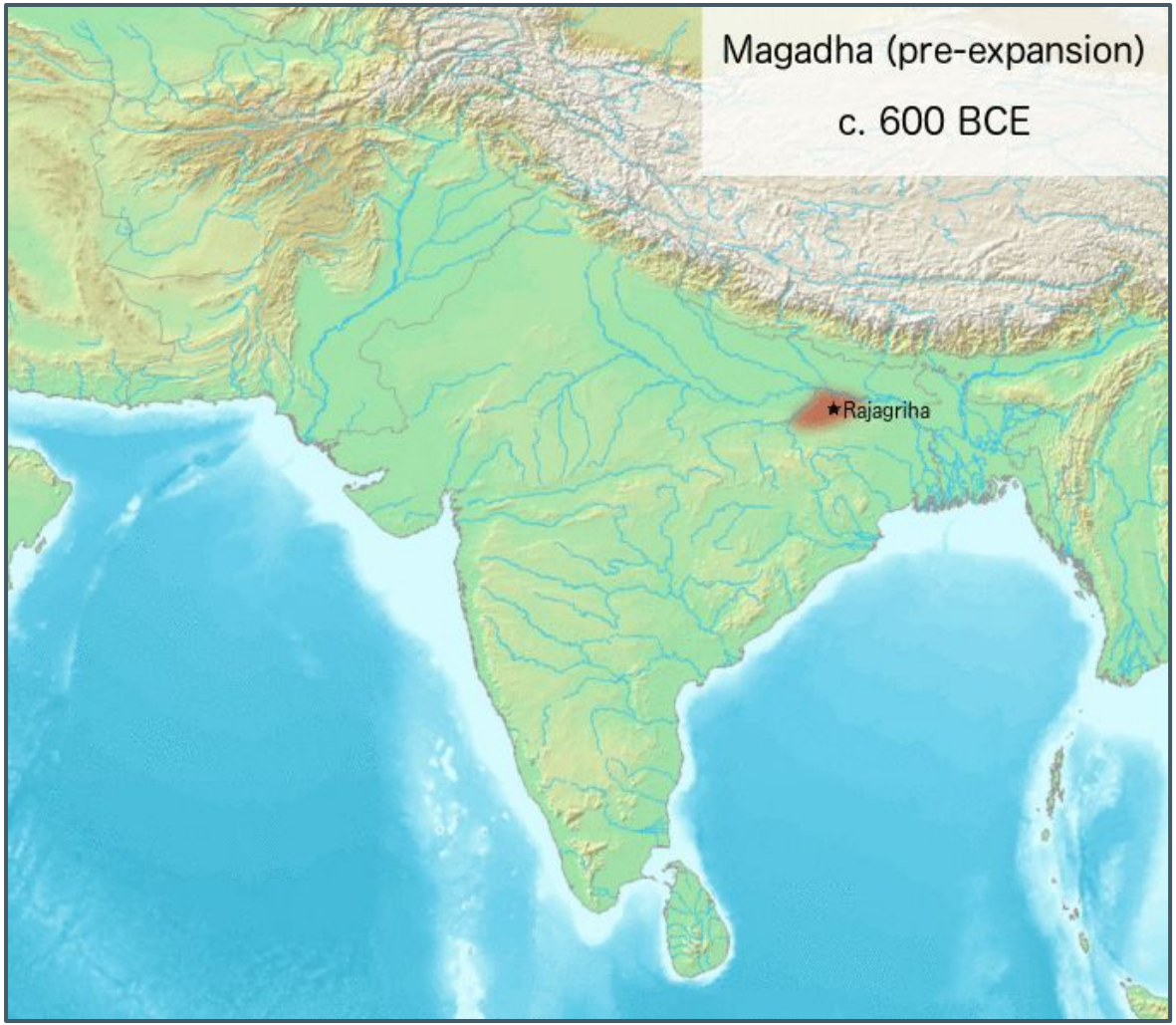


Bengal under the Mauryans

The Mauryans unified most parts of the Indian subcontinent.

During this time, the Mauryans built the Grand Trunk Road which facilitated the trade and attracted people from around the globe.

Emperor Asoka played an important role by sponsoring Buddhism. He sent missionaries, bureaucrats and trades in various places with Buddhist artifacts & doctrine. This diplomatic move connected Bengal with other regions of the subcontinent and especially south-east Asia.



Bengal under the Guptas

Bengal was an important province of the Guptas.

During this time, the Guptas enforced well-organized administrative system.

This era witnessed the development of art and sculpture.

This is the second time after the Mauryans Bengal became part of and connected to the other parts of Indian subcontinent under one administration



Local rulers from Bengal- the Pala, Sena, Deva, Chandra, Verman- helped to establish a strong regional identity of Bengal. They sponsored learning centers, excelled in trade, maintained religious harmony, instrumentalized a welcoming administrative system.

Contributions of the Rulers from Bengal

- Shashanka, the king of Gauda Kingdom, developed the Bengali Calendar - 'Bangabdo'

- The Palas directly sponsored several learning institutions such as Somapura Mahavihara, Nalanda Mahavihara and Vikramshila Mahavihara. They helped to spread Buddhism and Buddhist art in Bengal.

- During this time, Bengali as the language of this land took the central stage. Several Sanskrit and Pali texts were written and translated into Tibetan and Chinese.

- Admixture of Hindu and Buddhist doctrine into the social fabric of Bengal

Somapura Mahavihara established by Dharmapala in 6th century



Shalvan Mahavihara established by Bhavadeva in 8th century



Ancient seat of Learning

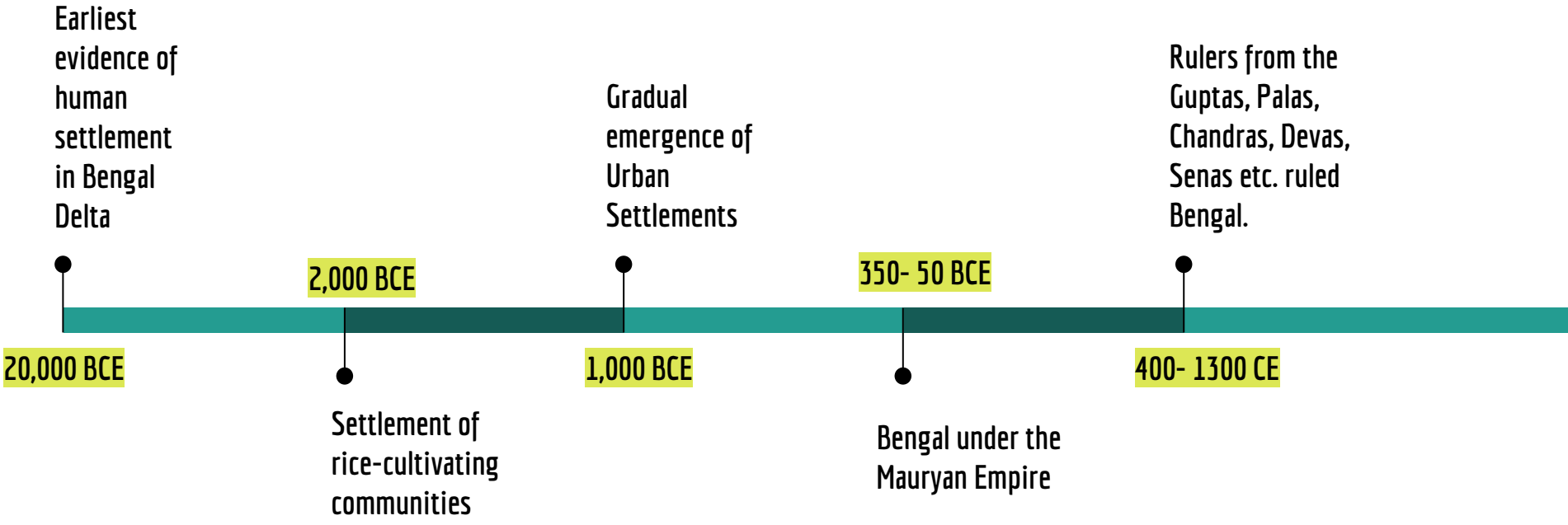
Pre-Islamic Bengal experience excellence in knowledge because of the state-sponsored learning centers. Several scholars from Bengal contributed immensely to the field of knowledge of Philosophy, Science and Arts.



Atish Dipankar was one of the pioneers of Buddhist philosophy. He home is in Bikrampur, commonly known as *Nastik Panditer Bhita*. He was invited by the king of Tibet to teach Buddhism in Tibet. He pioneered the Mahayana and Vajrayana Buddhism.

"... in this complex world of multiple and transforming religious identities a new creed, Islam, entered in two seperate waves. In first, reached coastal bangladesh as a by-product of seaborne trade between the eighth and twelfth centuries". Secondly, "in the early thirteenth century Islam also reached Bangladesh by land route, this time as the religion of powerful invaders."

History of Bangladesh | Willem van Schendel | 2009


Earliest evidence of human settlement in Bengal Delta
20,000 BCE
2,000 BCE
Settlement of rice-cultivating communities
Gradual emergence of Urban Settlements
1,000 BCE
350- 50 BCE
Bengal under the Mauryan Empire
Rulers from the Guptas, Palas, Chandras, Devas, Senas etc. ruled Bengal.
400- 1300 CE

Suggested Readings

Required Reading:
Salahuddin, A. F. (2004). *Bangladesh National Culture and Heritage.* Dhaka : IUB.
Pages: 53-65

Recommended Readings:

Sengupta, N. (2011). *Land of Two Rivers*. India: Penguin Books

Rahim, M. A., Choudhury, A. M., Mahmud, A. B. M. & Islam, S. (2005). *Bangladesher Etihash (History of Bangladesh).* Dhaka: Nouruj Kitabistan.



Next Class Preview

From Origins of Bengal Sultanates to the Battle of Polashi (1204-1757): Society, Religion and Politics